

Jacob Van Leeuwen

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Citizenship: United States

Education:

Ph.D. Economics, Texas A&M University, 2025

B.S. Economics and Statistics, Brigham Young University, 2018

Research and Teaching Interests:

Applied Microeconomics, Public Economics, Economic History, Urban Economics

Working Papers:

“The long-run and intergenerational effects of natural disaster exposure: Evidence from the Galveston Hurricane of 1900”

(Job Market Paper)

I use a natural experiment to examine the long-term and intergenerational effects of exposure to natural disasters, exploring how where we live can have long-lasting impacts. I examine outcomes of individuals impacted by the Galveston Hurricane of 1900, the deadliest and one of the most costly natural disasters in US history. Using historic newspaper records, I identify towns that sustained significant physical damage or were completely destroyed by the storm. Leveraging linked US Census records and IPUMS Full Count Census Data from 1880-1940, I find that individuals living in affected towns in southeast Texas in 1900 were more likely to migrate, had worse labor market outcomes, poorer literacy, and shorter lifespans compared to similar individuals in nearby unaffected towns. These negative effects persisted into the next generation, pointing to both persistent long-run and intergenerational effects of natural disaster exposure, which may be driven by individuals' migration behavior.

“The Socioeconomic Effects of Forced Displacement: Evidence from the Tennessee Valley Authority” with Andre’ay Harris (submitted to *Journal of Economic Growth*)

We examine the socioeconomic effects of forced migration using individuals who were displaced by the Tennessee Valley Authority (TVA) dam projects in the 1930s. To estimate the effect of forced migration, we use data from the relocation program associated with the TVA and link it to US Census data using record linking methods. We compare individuals living in counties that were impacted by the dam-induced flooding with nearby counties that would have been affected had the dams been in a different location. We find evidence that individuals who were impacted by the dam projects are more likely to participate in the labor force, with an influx into unskilled occupations. They are also more likely to pay higher rent prices conditional on renting. We examine racial disparities in outcomes and find that Black families see a higher increase in rent prices and Black men are more likely to switch into unskilled occupations compared to White families and White men after the relocation.

“The long run effects of anti-immigrant institutional discrimination: Evidence from Philadelphia”

I estimate the long-run and intergenerational effects of institutional discrimination using a policy targeting Irish immigrants in 19th century Philadelphia. To do this, I construct a panel of US Census data from 1850 to 1910 linked to inmate data from a large prison, and find that the rate of incarceration for Irish men increased following the implementation of the policy. Using a differences-in-differences design, I find that impacted Irish individuals had worse labor market outcomes nearly 25 years after the enactment of the policy, and are more likely to move to a different county. While the effects of the discriminatory policy do not persist across generations on average, first-generation mobility contributes to the persistence of effects. Irish individuals who moved from Philadelphia and their children are less negatively affected than those who stayed, suggesting that institutional discrimination has lasting effects for those unable to move away from the source of the discrimination.

"The Orphan Train Experiment: The Impact of America's First Large-Scale Child Welfare Program"
with Maxwell Bullard

This project evaluates the lifetime and intergenerational impact of place on socioeconomic outcomes using evidence from the Orphan Train Movement, the relocation of several hundred thousand orphaned and surrendered children in New York City to families across the U.S. from 1853 to 1929. We estimate the impact of place, defined as a set of county-level characteristics, by exploiting a placement mechanism within a sample of orphanages which generated quasi-random assignment of children to locations across the U.S. The outcomes for these children, called Orphan Train riders, are examined on a broad set of measures as well as for their descendants. To do this, we develop a novel dataset by digitizing information from historical ledgers, research documents, and state-level censuses to identify children in participating orphanages. We link these data to a panel of complete-count decennial U.S. Censuses from 1850 to 1940. Our findings suggest that riders who were placed in more residentially developed, wealthy, and populous counties have higher lifetime occupational income scores, have fewer children, and are less likely to farm. These effects persist into the subsequent generation.

Works in Progress:

“The persistent effects of institutional discrimination on household wealth: Evidence from Asian discrimination”

"Ugly Laws and Ugly(?) Outcomes" with Melissa Gentry

Publications:

"Male-biased sex ratios, marriage, and household composition in early twentieth-century Hawai‘i." *Asia-Pacific Economic History Review* (2024). with Sumner La Croix, Timothy Halliday, and Joseph Price

“Using Linked Census Records to Study Shrinking Cities in the United States from 1900 to 1940”, *The Professional Geographer* (2022) , with Samuel Otterstrom and Joseph Price

“Combining family history and machine learning to link historical records: The Census Tree data set.” *Explorations in Economic History* 80 (2021): 101391, with Joseph Price, Kasey Buckles, and Isaac Riley

“Baseball and Life Expectancy: Evidence from Linked Data” *Historical Perspectives on Sports Economics* (2019), with Joseph Price and Sebastian Brown

Teaching Experience:

Primary Instructor, Public Finance, Texas A&M University, 2024 (Course evaluation: 4.1/5.0)

Teaching Assistant, Introduction to Econometrics, Texas A&M University, 2021- 2022

Teaching Assistant, Applied Econometrics, Brigham Young University, 2018

Research Experience:

Postdoctoral Research Associate, Record Linking Lab, Brigham Young University, 2025-present

Graduate Research Assistant, Department of Economics, Texas A&M University, 2020-2025

Research Assistant, Department of Economics, Brigham Young University, 2016-2020

Presentations:

IPUMS Data-intensive Research Conference, 2025

Mountain West Economic History Conference, 2025

Texas Empirical Applied Microeconomics Student Workshop, 2024

References:

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